SUBLIME: AN OPEN APPROACH TO COLLABORATIVE PERFORMANCE

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ABSTRACT

Over two weeks in March 2014, computer based sound/visual and dance creative practitioners developed new works in the unstructured workshop environment titled *Sublime* in the Newport Substation, a collaborative event auspiced by Ausdance and the Victorian College of the Arts. This presentation maps the development of artworks across that fortnight. The time can roughly be split into: the first week, in which a shared language was developed between the different groups of practitioners; and the second week in which these commonalities were explored and developed in the production of new integrated performance pieces.

This paper discusses the collaborative development of three works that involved each of the above areas in their development and implementation. It outlines the structure of the workshop, the different approaches and processes if the various participants, and the process for discovering commonalities in practice, approach, and language in order to harmonize the various outcomes.

1. INTRODUCTION

Sublime came about through an invitation from Andy Howitt, Ausdance director, to Roger Alsop to develop a collaborative situation in which sound, visual, and dance artists could develop new works in a fully collaborative and improvised way. Jeremy Gaden, director of the Newport Substation, provided the location, allowing access to unused spaces: a large and smaller hall, shown in **Figure 1** and **Figure 2**, and a balcony shown in **Figure 3** below.

The intention was to create an outcome in which all aspects were originated in the workshops. Alsop and Howitt ensured that there was as little preplanning or pre-intentionality as possible, believing that to develop any outcomes from as open a philosophical and practical position as possible would allow all involved to have equal agency, opportunity, and input.

With no 'top-down' methodology this approach rendered problems in the first few days as participants anticipated or expected a brief, or guiding hand. However this process proved very effective in creating harmonious outcomes in all respects and across the three art forms, including a strong sense of personal and group agency; interaction in which all parts and participants were considered essential in the development of each works and to any potential outcomes; and a sense that all of the final works were intertwined. This intertwining was facilitated by the sense that all works were being developed concurrently from a neutral base, and that all participants could contribute in areas they wanted to, regardless of previous activities and experience, or relation to a specific art form.

Over the two weeks of development Howitt took an active role as a dancer/choreographer, and Alsop took a more curatorial/ facilitator role. This resulted in Howitt having an involved position, internal to his work, and Alsop becoming a less involved 'outside eye'.

A goal in the creation of *Sublime* was that the focus be on developing dialogs and interactions between the creators working in areas that they felt most comfortable in. Discussion of various technologies and systems, while not discouraged, was not prevalent while 'on the floor'. In this respect it was good to see that the conversations mostly transcended the process, instead focusing on the outcomes and keeping these aspects as opaque as possible.

2. PROCESSES FOR DEVELOPING A HARMONIC RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN ART FORMS

2.1. Creating and experiencing harmony

The simultaneous combination of narratives to form a consistent whole[1] of is an essence in the arts. In the performed arts these combinations are represented through sound and vision, such as hearing and seeing actors, and seeing dancers and hearing music. Many ways of creating a seamless harmony between these elements have been used, ranging from the last minute coalescing of choreography, décor and music of Cunningham, Rauschenberg and Cage [1], the multi-faceted approach of Robert Wilson, who works in all roles of performance creation [2], to the continually varying but fully collaborative/interactive approaches of Robert Lepage [3].

Discussing the interrelationships between sound and image in film, Deutsch (4) saw "the sound that accompanies visuals not merely as a combination of disparate disciplines, but as a unified and coherent entity [, where] music, dialogue, effects and atmospheres are heard as interdependent layers."

Film is an art form in which the interaction between sound (sound effects and music), narrative (the story),

[1] To paraphrase the Apple dictionary definition of 'harmony'

and visual image (actions, props, locations, costumes, etc.) is required to make a successful whole. In the better iterations of this art form the result is more than the sum of these parts, as is the case for all art forms in which intertwining elements are presented.

2.2. Space and Harmony

Harmony is dependent on empty spaces. This emptiness allows the various resonances of different voices to intertwine and coalesce. These spaces may be analogous to Burrows (5) three fields, a sensorial, observed physical space, mental space of potential options, or diffused spiritual space, which, through an input, coalesce and are subsumed to provide a fulfilled and singular whole: a harmonic outcome. Bachelard (6) saw the varieties of experience within domestic space; the dark, irrational harmonies of the cellar and lighter, intimate, harmonies of walls, furniture, or a chest of drawers. These framings of the term provide a way conceiving harmony as a meta term, in which harmony is a sense derived from the confluences of materials and transitory input or influences.

2.3. Notation and Harmony

Brooks (7) discussed Laban's concept of 'space harmony', drawing together his senses of architecture, movement and music to consider relationships between vertical, horizontal and sagittal spaces in a philosophy that considered the relations of these aspects of the body to each other and the space(s) encompassing them. Laban's notation process was based on the 'quadricosahedron', where three dimensional space is into 27 directions [8], demonstrating that movement into and in relation to space was conceptually paramount.

Musical notation has been used to demonstrate and develop approaches to creating 'harmonic' outcomes. Here the residual resonances of simultaneous sonic events are linked to create a sense of harmony in the perceiver's mind. In early western music these resonances were influenced by the space in which the sounds were propagated, and this space influenced the choices of sounds created.

2.4. The human body and harmony

Bachelard and Burrows offered approaches to considering harmony beyond the sonic or arts based understanding of the word, giving it social, locational, physical, psychological and spiritual dimensions. These are all experienced through and within the human body, and Laban indicated a formalized way to understand and generate strands that can entwine to form harmony possible between the body and its surrounding space.

In the pieces developed in Sublime a process of understanding the unique relationships between the dancer as physical object, the environment and props as physical objects, and sound and projected image as on-physical objects was developed. A conceptual harmony between concept and object was developed and this in turn created an observed harmony between concept and object and finally an intended harmony between concept and object.

3. TIMELINE FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF SUBLIME

As stated, the Sublime workshop occurred over the course of two weeks at the Substation gallery in Newport and the timeline for the development of works can roughly be split into two parts. The first week, in which participants began to get to know one another and their practices, and the second week in which the established dialogues from the first week were exploited to develop the artworks already in progress. This section offers a break-down of the activities of each discipline, video, sound and dance within each of the two weeks before discussing the (continual) outcomes of Sublime.

3.1. Video

Within the first two days of *Sublime* elements of possible projection were discussed amongst visual artists with an emphasis on silhouette and shadow. These elements were selected for their ability to be either subtle or bold and sit within a variety of environments. This was seen as a way of not 'getting in the way of the dancers' nor 'imposing an idea' but instead being something that could be cajoled to work with the choreography devised by the dancers.

Over the course of the week, through the drawing from code devised for previous projects, a projection element consisting of an array of circular shadows was devised. Mid-way through the week this was also given a rudimentary beat detection algorithm allowing the sound being developed within the space to affect the size and movement of the shadows.

By the second week the projection had gained a discreet options menu that allowed for size, motion, opacity and other properties of the shadows to be controlled in real-time. This, along with an improved beat detection and access to discreet audio rather than relying on ambient sound from microphones improved the quality and responsiveness of the projection to the sound and dance within the space. Further refinements to the program continued for the rest of the week including adding additional real-time options to modify the effects at specific points of the performances.

There was no mapping of the images to the shape of the inflatable being projected on; this decision was both pragmatic and aesthetic. Firstly, the shape of the inflatable was impossible to predict until it was completely inflated, and then the orientation of it in relation to the positions of projectors altered each time it was inflated.

Secondly, the group thought that by allowing the projected images to be influenced by the inflatable being projected on they would reflect a greater relationship to it. The shape of the images morphed between circular blobs and straight lines, and the varying shape and position of the inflatable made the projected images take on new and unique shapes as it was being inflated and interacted with by the dancers.



Figure 1. Dancer inside the Inflatable

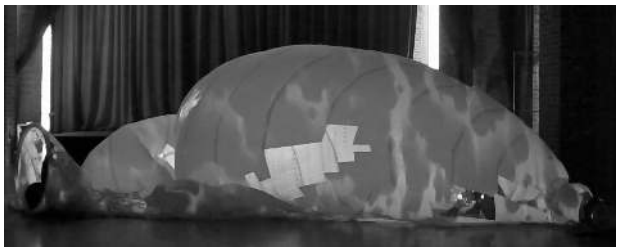


Figure 2. Inflatable with two dancers.

3.2. Sound

All sound artists involved within the Sublime project drew their inspiration, first, from the environment itself. This would eventuate in a long-form composition by one of the sound artists to accompany the "SpaceWorm" work which was inspired by the sounds of air conditioners and the fan which pumped-up the inflatable during the performance.

The second sound artist working within the project continued to respond in real time through an electric guitar augmented through a layering of effects. This element of sound production was used within the work in the upstairs corridor within the gallery space. This impromptu sound-creation element was well suited for the workshop environment due to its on-the-fly ability to change with the other elements of dance and projection as they developed.

3.3. Dance

Over the course of the first week two separate dance performances developed. The first involved two dancers within the main space this piece being devised around a large inflatable: a second piece was developed by a solo dancer within a corridor of the gallery. For the first week the dancers in both spaces spent their time becoming accustomed to the space and in the case of the duo working with the inflatable, developing a rapport with the way in which it moved and inflated.

By mid-second week the dancers had well-developed performances within their respective spaces and concentration turned to refining their movements.

3.4. Harmony

While it is useful to outline the discreet elements involved in Sublime (video, sound, dance), the harmony within these performances was only achieved through conversations between the creative practitioners.

The development of the projection over the course of the two weeks was defined by a reflexive engagement with the developing performance and sound elements both through active listening and watching by the visual coder as well as conversations with other parties regarding their personal aims for their elements.

Late in the first week, a conversation between the projection artist and the solo dancer in the upstairs corridor (shown in **Figure 3**) lead to a discussion of the story that the dancer had developed for her performance. Part of this story involved the dancer exploring the limitations of her brain's control over her body by simultaneously producing rapid movement with her arm and torso while aiming to move with careful and controlled motion from her hips and legs. This 'split' became a useful visual metaphor and new code was developed to allow for a splitting of the visuals into a fast/slow halves in order to complement these movements.

Similarly, after development of easier real-time modification of the visuals in the second week, a conversation took place between the visual controller and the dancers in the main auditorium space. This conversation allowed the dancers to speak of their narrative intentions for their performance and seek more information on the limitations of the projection element. From this conversation the dancer's structure was solidified to the visual artist who could then respond more readily to these changes through modification of the projection during the performance.

3.5. The 'third work'

If in the second week a harmony was developing between the practitioners, by the Thursday of the second week it had become a song. By this time the two works were well developed and new opportunities could be explored. As the separate practitioners had come to know each other over the course of the two weeks conversations had turned from immediate concerns of the works to instead commonalities within wider theoretical and conceptual concerns.

It was from one of these conversations during downtime that one of the sound artists and one of the dancers began to discuss a mutual interest in social theatre. From this discussion these practitioners, along with a third artist who supplied motion detection technology, developed a new sound/dance performance in the last two days of the workshop.

3.6. Temporal Integration

In their paper, "Temporal Integration of Interactive Technology in Dance: Creative Process Impacts", Latulipe, Wilson (9) discuss the ability of technology to impact on choreographic development within dance productions. Referencing the aspects of time that are involved in the development/choreographing of new dance works they state, "If props are available for use at the beginning of the process, they are more likely to be well-integrated into the choreography." The ability for these 'props', which encompass any element that integrates with performance such as costume, staging or

technologies, to affect the choreography is labelled as "temporal integration effects". Through mapping of the integration of elements of the dance production Latilupe et al shows the challenges that can be produced when new elements are added part-way through the creative process. But this can also lead to new possibilities and responsiveness within the performance and therefore should not be maligned.

The performances Latulipe et al developed and interrogate within their article are structured works in which a top-down directive was in place. This can be understood from the references to 'teaching' the choreography to the dancers. However, within the Sublime project there were no such leaders or directors, rather decisions were made through conversation and negotiation, which naturally leads to a less rigid environment of creation.

Within the Sublime project the absence of defined specific outcome or public performance, meant that temporal integration effects were less problematic and additions of new ideas, technology and props were embraced within the workshop environment.

An example of this is the corridor work that added new elements during the course of the workshop. As previously mentioned this work was developed without projection or sound for half of the first week before a projection element was added. Towards the end of the second week sound artist Camille Robinson began to produce sound which responded in real-time to the movement and context.

It is the addition mid-second week, however, of motion tracking technology, which relates most clearly to the temporal integration effect. Mark Pedersen, another of the collaborating artists designed and built a Bluetooth motion-tracking glove using Arduimo hardware, allowing information to be streamed in real time regarding the pitch, roll and yaw of the performer's arm. The artist producing the visuals had not worked with this technology previously and thus a learning curve for integration of the information streamed from the device into the visual projection was limited to just a few days.

While not successful in developing a complex responsiveness based on the movement information a basic modification to the colour of the projection based on the speed of the dancer's arm was introduced to the work which helped to contrast the calm beginnings of the work to the faster, jerkier movements of the climax of the performance. This addition would not have been possible within a more structured environment in which specific outcomes were expected.

The third work, developed over the course of two days at the end of the workshop however, could be situated more readily within Latilupe et al's creative process. The technology and sound were integrated from the outset of the work and developed along with the movement of the dancer. However, this work only came about due to the previous non-structured environment in which the first two works were created; an environment in which each practitioner was free to input new ideas and show 'what they could do' to the larger group, rather than an environment in which specific structures defined the input of individuals.

4. FIRST-HAND EXPERIENCE

In this section the authors consider their personal responses to the development of the works discussed. Their roles evolved to have Cox taking that of a creative agent responding to the developments of the locations and the dancers and their actions, and Alsop having a more facilitator and 'out side eye' role, discussing the experience of the works from an audience point of view.

Cox engaged with the artworks as the producer of the projection element within both the inflatable and corridor works. The projection itself was produced in real-time within the Processing environment with variables modified in response to the changes in the dancer's movements. This code base was shared across both projects, though with different variable settings in order to create different effects.

As stated, the aims when developing the projection were to work in harmony with other elements of Sublime, especially the other visual element, the dancers. Cox produced a simple 'shadow' generator of dark ellipses drifting vertically across a white screen. These spheres played well across surfaces when projected and allowed for an emphasis of the forms that they encountered (including the dancer's bodies) rather then a neutralisation of their ground. As this was produced within the first few days of the workshop it was unknown how this projection would be used as the performances developed.

As the dancers within the main space began to move and perform with the inflatable over the first week Cox began to darken the room and project over their movements, aiming to find the best location and distance to project from. This was also when he began to converse with the dancer performing upstairs regarding the aims for her own performance. From the conversations he began to use the same projection upstairs with her, modifying the size and movement of ellipses to facilitate the more intimate nature of her piece.

While simplistic in appearance, the variability of the visuals generated through real-time modification of variables allowed for a wide variety of effects to be achieved. The larger performance using the inflatable can be characterised as large, uncontrolled and imposing, while the upstairs performance was more intimate and considered. The ease with which I could modify the projection allowed for Cox to align with both the downstairs performance by producing large, brash shapes and plunging the entire space into light or shadow, and also with the upstairs work with it's smaller shapes projected onto the dancer's body creating an intimacy and a highlighting of the dancer's body as she moved.

Alsop viewed each work in various stages of their development. The Balcony work had become a well-

developed work with a clear trajectory, intent and outcome, ready for performance in its space, it showed and well considered process, one in which all participants were able to understand the thrust of the work and respond to it with little need for on-going discussion between the participants. It provided an intimate experience for the viewer, focussing attention on the minutia of the dancers movement and the subtle projections provided by Cox. Highly processes guitar music was improvised by Camille Robinson, and this provided a lush, but subtle, backdrop to the visual experience.



Figure 3. Dancer in the corridor space

The Inflatable was a more open piece. While there were intentions to develop a more complete work, the process, and added prop, created a sense of many fertile options. It was decided to allow this, with the sense of developing a series of works that may go to different spaces and contexts.

Viewing the work as it was shown at the end of the workshop, it was clear that this was the best option; but to consider it as a performance the adjective that best describe it are loud, hard, uncontrolled, and intimidating; but enveloping, intriguing and subsuming would be as appropriate. This diversity of response led the group to consider how each of these intellectual and emotional spaces might best be developed in performance and in interaction with the audience and performance space.

5. CONCLUSION

In an environment without directorial control or expected outcomes it can be difficult to recognize whether a workshop can be marked as successful or a failure. If we consider the development of performances and introduction and connection between creative peers Sublime can be marked as a success. Of course this is not to suggest that throwing a handful of creative people into a room will always produce such results. There must be recognition of the structure and support available to the practitioners including, a large amount of space and freedom, access to varied and plentiful technology on-site and the non-structured schedule allowing artists to work within the space at times conducive and convenient for themselves.

The disparate elements of the Sublime project developed over the course of two weeks into a cohesive whole. Sublime shows that a model of non-top-down authority when combined with confident practitioners can develop new relationships and performances that can continue to be leveraged in the future. To this end the individuals involved within Sublime continue to be in contact and are currently exploring opportunities to perform the outcomes to a wider audience as well as produce new works.

6. REFERENCES

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